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three contenders among states in terms of tourist footfalls, Rajasthan now ranks sixth in international tourist arrivals and 10th for domestic tourists, says Gayatri Rathore, the state's principal secretary, tourism. "But we are committed to be back in the top three," she adds.

The industry status accorded to tourism has helped. In March this year, the Gehlot government issued a notification announcing that power tariffs for tourism-related units will be on par with industrial units. There have been a series of notifications since then, including one that allows owners to register tourism units online in order to qualify for lower taxes and other benefits.

Hoteliers are jubilant—they will now have better cash liquidity to expand their properties. They also expect to save as much as 20 per cent of the running cost. "Even 2-3 per cent savings matter a lot in our sector," says Ashok Rathore, general manager of Rambagh Palace, Jaipur, a luxury heritage hotel managed by the Taj group. The new measures have also spurred big businesses and international hotel chains to scout the state's vast heritage to either take over existing hotels or to build new ones.

Another Rs 1,000 crore has been earmarked in the state budget for the tourism sector. The figure includes a development fund of Rs 500 crore for 2022-23 and a similar amount allocated in 2021-22. Of this, Rs 600 crore will be spent on infrastructure, including building toilets at places of tourist interest, and the rest on promotional activities.

Randhir Singh Mandawa, president of the Indian Heritage Hotels Association (IHHA), says he was pleasantly surprised when Rajasthan tourism minister Vishvendra Singh called him earlier this year to inform him about the relief measures for tourism. "Ministers rarely call to inform you about such decisions," says Mandawa. This reflects a change in the government's approach to tourism. "For the first time, the government is willing to involve stakeholders at every stage," says Ranvijay Singh Rathore, joint secretary, Hotel and Restaurant Association of Rajasthan (HRAR).

Minister Singh says the government must accept good ideas from anyone who makes a living from tourism.

GIFTS FROM GEHLOT

The Rajasthan government has announced a slew of benefits for the tourism sector. Here is a list of the key ones:

- One of the top hotels in Jaipur is paying Rs 3 lakh instead of Rs 22 lakh in urban development taxes. It has also got Rs 1.5 crore in refund of state GST for losses during Covid-induced lockdowns
- A 50-room hotel may save Rs 1 lakh a month on electricity bills due to lowered tariffs
- Rs 1 crore subsidy for filmmakers if a major part of a movie is shot in Rajasthan
- Near or total waiver of stamp duty, land conversion charges and state GST for hotels and restaurants coming up in rural settings, and substantial concessions in urban areas, too
- Refund of interest up to 6 per cent on certain loans for most tourism projects

And the approach seems to have takers among the executive. Principal secretary Rathore says she considers IHHA, HRAR, the Federation of Hospitality and Tourism Rajasthan (FHTR), the Rajasthan Association of Tour Operators (RATO), etc. as her department's partners in promoting the sector. "Rajasthan Tourism will join hands with FHTR to organise pre-event roadshows in different parts of India and hold district-level investors' meets," she says.

For a change, tourism bodies, which have generally been critical of the government, have expressed hope this time. "The government has provided a generous budget allocation to the tourism industry," says FHTR president Apurv Kumar, referring to the Rs 1,000 crore set aside for tourism. A number of other policies, which will help hotels, cafes, resorts, bars, museums etc., are also on the cards, says minister Singh. Then there's the CM's Small Scale Units Promotion Scheme, which offers subsidised loans to people to set up enterprises.

However, there is also a section that feels it is too early to rejoice. "We don't know whether the recent measures will ultimately benefit anyone or are aimed only at fast-tracking the files of some select projects," says a prominent hotelier. Gaj Singh Alsisar, who runs a few hotels in the state and is building a new one in Khetri, finds the process of registrations and getting fire safety NOCs (no-objection certificates) cumbersome, and feels that norms must be relaxed for heritage hotels, many of which are not covered under town fire safety rules as they are located outside municipal limits. HRAR treasurer Kunal Kuchhal, who runs a few restaurants in Jaipur, says dozens of clearances are needed to launch a restaurant. "The government must make it more convenient for us." A few hoteliers are also resisting a tax being proposed by municipalities for every room booking, saying such a measure will negate the benefits extended by the new policy.

It remains to be seen whether the concessions are enough to address such concerns. More importantly, however, the government has to ensure that the promises made to the industry don't fall through the cracks. ■